

CodeChef Director of Operations Visits @ IIIT Pune

IIIT Pune recently hosted Mr. Suraj Sharma, Director of Operations at CodeChef, for a day-long visit on 27/08/2026 aimed at strengthening the institute's competitive programming ecosystem and exploring avenues for deeper collaboration between CodeChef and IIIT Pune.

The visit began with a meeting between honorable Director sir, Dr. Nagendra Kushwaha, ICPC Nodal Officer, HOD CSE, TPO, SAC In-charge and Mr. Suraj Sharma. The discussion focused on exploring ways to strengthen the CodeChef and IIIT Pune's partnership and lay the groundwork for future collaborative initiatives.

Mr. Sharma next met with 25+ members of the coding club in the Conference Room for a focused technical interaction. The conversation centered on the CodeChef-IIIT Pune partnership, strategies to further improve the coding culture on campus, and ways to encourage greater female participation in ICPC. The session was attended by faculty members Dr. Priyank Jain, Dr. Sumit Kumar Gupta, Dr. Shivangi Shukla, Dr. Mahendra Pratap Yadav, Dr. Sonam Maurya.





The highlight of the visit was an interactive session held in the Auditorium for around 350 students, predominantly first years. Mr. Sharma spoke about the transition from a school mindset to an engineering mindset: moving from structured, penalized for mistakes learning to open ended, iterative problem solving where experimentation and errors are part of the process. The session featured an engaging conversation on coding in the age of AI, exploring the enduring value of strong problem solving and data structures and algorithms fundamentals even as AI tools become more capable. Mr. Sharma addressed common myths around learning to code, that one needs to be a math genius, that it is too late to start, or that every syntax rule must be memorized and emphasized that the discipline is largely about logic and debugging rather than syntax alone. He shared inspiring examples of students from modest coding backgrounds who went on to represent their institutions and country at the ICPC World Finals, underscoring that consistent, active learning through problem solving and project building is more valuable than passive learning. The session concluded with an interactive question and answer round with the audience.



The visit concluded with an interaction session with the faculty in the Conference Room, attended by around 25+ faculty members, where a productive discussion took place on strengthening the coding culture at IIIT Pune. The visit reflects IIIT Pune's continued commitment to fostering a strong competitive programming culture and building meaningful industry partnerships that benefit its student community.